

E-store brand personality congruence for multichannel apparel retail brands

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims at examining the role of the e-store brand personality congruence/incongruence of a multichannel apparel retailer in the formation of consumers' perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention, based on the concept of image congruence.

Design/methodology/approach – An online survey was conducted with a US national sample of 458 female consumers (20–50 years old) who had shopped for clothing online.

Findings – Results revealed that e-store brand personality incongruence in three personality dimensions had a negative impact on consumers' e-store patronage intention directly as well as indirectly by reducing the consumers' global perception of the e-store brand fit. Further, the retailer's relevance to the consumer moderated the relationship between the perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention in that this relationship was significantly greater among consumers with a high (vs low) perceived self-relevance of the retail brand.

Practical implications – The findings highlight the importance of symbolically integrated cross-channel brand management for multichannel apparel retailers by clearly identifying their brand personality and carefully crafting it into their e-store interface design and e-store visual merchandising to convey the brand personality.

Originality/value – This study expands the application of image congruence to the cross-channel image congruence phenomenon in multichannel retailing environments by examining the e-store brand image congruence employing both direct and indirect approaches.

Keywords Brand personality, Perceived fit, Patronage intention, Image congruence, Multichannel retailers

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Today's consumers are multichannel shoppers and frequently exposed to the same retailer from multiple channels, which makes them expect consistent shopping experiences from the retailer across all channels (Cho and Workman, 2011; Lazar, 2019). Consumers' perceptions and behaviors toward the brand in one channel can be affected by their experiences and perceptions from another channel (Cho and Workman, 2011; Payne *et al.*, 2017). E-stores (also called online stores or retail websites) are particularly instrumental for consumers' purchase decisions. E-commerce sales accounted for 14.3% of all retail sales worldwide in 2018 (Ali, 2019) and have seen incessant growths for the last decade with growths of 13–17% every year in the US, while US total retail sales annual growths have remained at 2–7% during the same period (Ali, 2019; US Census Bureau, 2019). More than 65% of US shoppers conduct online research before they buy products (Thomsen, 2018), and an average shopper visits an e-store 9.5 times before making a purchase (Lazar, 2019). Therefore, e-stores play critical roles in building, reinforcing and extending a retailer's brand image, which highlights the importance of integrated management between a retailer's existing brand image and its e-store image. Nevertheless, few researchers have examined how the congruence/incongruence



between a retail brand's existing brand image and its e-store image may impact consumers' response, a gap addressed in this study.

The integrated marketing communication (IMC) paradigm postulates that all forms of marketing communication, regardless of the channel or media used, must be managed to integrate and interact with each other in order to maximize the brand value (Luck and Moffatt, 2009; Patti *et al.*, 2017). In line with the IMC concept, integrating diverse retail formats and maintaining an integrated concept by delivering a consistent brand image across channels is one of the critical challenges faced by multichannel retailers (Kim *et al.*, 2005; Lee and Atkinson, 2019; Payne *et al.*, 2017). Brand image consists of both functional and symbolic image dimensions (Keller, 1993; Hu *et al.*, 2012), and both symbolic and functional image congruence is significant for a successful multichannel branding (Esmaeilpour, 2015; Hu *et al.*, 2012; Islam *et al.*, 2019; Lee and Atkinson, 2019). However, existing channel integration research has weighed in the functional integration (e.g. Kim *et al.*, 2005), such as integrations in management of the inventory, supply chain, or customer service; whereas the issue of cross-channel symbolic image integration has been rarely investigated in spite of its significant influence to produce positive consumer responses (Riley *et al.*, 2015). Therefore, this study will focus on the cross-channel integration from the symbolic image management perspective to fill the aforementioned literature gap by examining the role of e-store brand personality congruence/incongruence in the overall image fit between the brand and the e-store and its resultant effect on consumers' patronage intention.

Specifically, we chose personality as a critical symbolic brand image dimension to focus on in this study. Brand personality refers to the brand's human-like traits (Aaker, 1997; Esmaeilpour, 2015) and has been known to play an important role in consumers' symbolic use of brand image (Keller, 1993; Islam *et al.*, 2019). The personality perspective also has long been applied in the retail context as store personality (e.g. Martineau, 1958) and e-store personality (e.g. Okazaki, 2006; Poddar *et al.*, 2009) as a critical symbolic image factor to drive consumers' patronage behaviors, such as repeated shopping at the store/e-store (Esmaeilpour, 2015; Hongwei and Mukherjee, 2007), spending time in the store/e-store and spreading a positive word-of-mouth (Chang and Kwon, 2017). Hence, this study examines how the incongruence between a multichannel retailer's brand personality and e-store personality influences consumers' perceived e-store brand fit, or subjective global judgment of the overall fit of the e-store image with the retail brand's image, and how this overall fit perception leads to the consumer's e-store patronage intention.

Much literature on image congruence has been devoted to self-congruence effects, which refer to consumers' behaving favorably toward a brand or a store that they perceive to be congruent with their self-image and thus is relevant to themselves (Esmaeilpour, 2015; Islam *et al.*, 2019; Sirgy, 1985). The self-congruence literature suggests that even if consumers perceive that a multichannel retailer's e-store well represents the retailer's brand image, they are not likely to shop at the e-store if the retail brand is perceived to be irrelevant to them to begin with. Further, cognitive psychology theories, such as the elaboration likelihood model (Cacioppo and Petty, 1984), suggest that the personal relevance of a communication positively drives how critically individuals process information in the communication, leading to more issue-relevant attitudinal or behavioral responses to the communication. Therefore, this study examines the potential moderating role of the retail brand's self-relevance to the consumer in altering the relationship between consumers' perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention.

We used vertically-integrated multichannel apparel specialty retailers which sell only their own private label apparel products as the context of this study because symbolic congruence is of particular importance in apparel shopping given the highly experiential and expressive nature of the product (Esmaeilpour, 2015; Kim and Damhorst, 2010). Further, by using vertically-integrated specialty retailers, we avoided potential confounding effects of the interaction between the product brand image and the retail brand image.

Literature review and hypotheses

Brand personality and e-store personality

Brand image refers to a consumer's perception of a brand reflecting diverse associations about the brand held in the consumer's memory, encompassing product- or non-product-related attributes and functional or symbolic benefits characterizing the brand (Keller, 1993). Brand image has a strong connection to the consumer decision-making process (Kwon and Lennon, 2011; Ross and Harradine, 2011). Among many types of brand associations, consumers often associate brands with symbolic meanings beyond tangible benefits of product features or performance (Keller, 1993; Islam *et al.*, 2019). A large part of the symbolic brand associations constituting a brand's image is linked to user imagery (i.e. an image about people who would buy and use the brand) (Esmaeilpour, 2015; Reiley *et al.*, 2015). The user imagery leads consumers to view the brand as if it were a person and associate the brand with brand personality (Aaker, 1997; Okazaki, 2006; Reiley *et al.*, 2015; Samala and Singh, 2019), or a "set of human characteristics" (Aaker, 1997, p. 347). Brand personality has been extensively examined as a symbolic brand image dimension because of its pivotal role in driving consumer decision making (Esmaeilpour, 2015; Islam *et al.*, 2019).

Similarly, store image refers to an overall impression of a store as perceived by a consumer (Doyle and Fenwick, 1974–1975; Zimmer and Golden, 1988). Martineau (1958) described store image as "the way in which the store is defined in the shoppers' mind, partly by its functional qualities and partly by an aura of psychological attributes" (p. 47). Between functional and psychological aspects of a store image, Martineau (1958) argued that the subjectively-judged psychological image, or *store personality*, may have a greater impact on shoppers' responses. Just as brand personality addresses human-like traits of a brand, store personality also consists of human-like characteristics (e.g. sophisticated, enthusiastic and genuine) that consumers perceive a store possesses (d'Astous and Levesque, 2003; Michon *et al.*, 2015).

The concepts of store personality and brand personality have been expanded to the online context. For example, Okazaki (2006) examined online brand personalities of 270 e-stores of American brands in five countries and found that many brand personality dimensions that were previously identified for offline contexts were applicable to online contexts. Other researchers have also confirmed the applicability of traditional brand personality dimensions to measure website personality (Poddar *et al.*, 2009; Vigolo and Ugolini, 2016) across different cultures (Opoku and Hinson, 2006) or the applicability of store personality dimensions to e-store personality (Chang and Kwon, 2017). Therefore, extending the concept of store personality to e-store contexts, e-store personality is defined in this study as the human-like characteristics of an e-store perceived by consumers. E-store personality has been found to impact online consumers' perceptions and purchase intention with respect to the e-store (Poddar *et al.*, 2009).

E-store brand image congruence/incongruence

Image congruence refers to how congruent the images of two entities (e.g. brands, stores, products and consumers) are with each other (Eren-Erdogmus *et al.*, 2018; Sirgy *et al.*, 1997; Vigolo and Ugolini, 2016). In this study, two variables, perceived e-store brand fit and e-store brand personality (in)congruence, are conceptualized in the context of e-store brand image congruence. These two variables differ both conceptually and operationally. First, conceptually, e-store brand personality (in)congruence captures image (in)congruence only in the personality aspect. Personality is a type of symbolic brand associations constituting the brand's and the e-store's images. On the other hand, perceived e-store brand fit reflects the holistic image congruence from the similarity between the overall brand image, which encompasses all functional or symbolic brand associations (Keller, 1993) and the e-store image, or the overall impression of the e-store encompassing the functional and symbolic

attributes of the e-store (adapted from the definition of store image by Zimmer and Golden (1988) and Martineau (1958) discussed earlier).

Second, operationally, in this study, the direct approach is used to assess e-store brand fit, whereas e-store brand personality (in)congruence is measured using the indirect approach, based on the direct and indirect approaches to measuring image congruence frequently used in past studies (e.g. Sirgy *et al.*, 1997). The *direct* approach operationalizes image congruence as the holistic assessment by directly asking respondents to indicate how congruent the two images are (i.e. how well the two images fit) (Eren-Erdogmus *et al.*, 2018; Vigolo and Ugolini, 2016). On the other hand, the *indirect* approach to the operationalization of image congruence entails first separately measuring the images of each entity (e.g. the personality of the brand and that of the e-store), from which a discrepancy between the two image scores is estimated indirectly; a lower incongruence score would indicate higher image congruence (e.g. Esmailpour, 2015; Hu *et al.*, 2012; Sirgy *et al.*, 1997).

E-store brand personality congruence/incongruence

From the perspective of the IMC paradigm, Keller (2009) emphasized the importance of strategic selection and design of online marketing options that match communication options in other channels. In the same vein, Rubinstein and Griffiths (2001) argued two factors for online branding success: “integrating all the expression of the brand” and “delivering a consistent brand experience” (p. 400), which correspond to the symbolic and functional congruence, respectively (Hu *et al.*, 2012). Kwon and Lennon (2009) provided empirical support for this argument through their finding that retailers’ offline and online brand images had reciprocal influences on each other; specifically, consumers’ brand beliefs and attitudes in one channel were affected by their experience from the other channel. Further, Da Silva and Syed Alwi (2008) argued that the symbolic cross-channel brand image consistency relating to intangible and emotional values may provide a more sustainable competitive advantage than does the functional integration across channels (Riley *et al.*, 2015).

Despite the importance of the intangible symbolic image congruence in multichannel retail branding, most existing literature on channel integration has been mainly focused on operational (functional) integration. For instance, researchers rather stressed utilitarian integration in tangible attributes of the retailer, such as merchandise accessibility, product availability, customer service, product quality, price, privacy and security (Kim *et al.*, 2005; Hu *et al.*, 2012). They tended to leave out the symbolic integration of brand image, such as the esthetic impression of the e-store design that matches its brand personality despite the key role of symbolic brand image consistency in successful branding (Riley *et al.*, 2015). Addressing this gap, we identify personality as a symbolic image dimension applicable to both a multichannel retailer’s brand and e-store and define *e-store brand personality congruence (incongruence)* as the degree to which the personality a consumer perceives from a multichannel retailer’s e-store is similar to (deviates from) the brand personality that the consumer associates with the retailer based on his or her prior experience. Adopting an *indirect* approach to measure e-store brand personality (in)congruence, we used e-store brand incongruence (as opposed to congruence) as our variable name to match it with the discrepancy operationalization through the indirect method (i.e. taking the difference between brand personality and e-store personality scores).

Perceived e-store brand fit

Perceived fit refers to consumers’ holistic perception of the similarity, connectedness, or compatibility between two objects (Lafferty, 2007). The role of perceived fit in marketing has been extensively investigated in brand extension literature. Brand extension is defined as the use of an existing brand name (i.e. parent brand) for a new product (i.e. extension) in order to facilitate entering new product categories or new market segments (Aaker and Keller, 1992).

Perceived fit between the parent brand and the extension has been known to play a critical role in the success of a brand extension strategy (Aaker and Keller, 1992; Eren-Erdogmus *et al.*, 2018; Vigolo and Ugolini, 2016).

In this study, perceived e-store brand fit is defined as a consumer's subjective global judgment of how well an apparel retail brand's e-store reflects the brand. Offline retailers' expansion to the Internet is analogous to a product brand's extension into another product category (Kwon and Lennon, 2009). Just as product brand extensions use existing familiar name of their parent brands to take advantage of their halo effect to foster trust in new products (Chowdhury, 2007), offline retailers have expanded to the Internet under the same retailer name that they have used offline (e.g. Macy's launching macys.com) in order to leverage positive existing brand images to reduce consumers' perceived risk and enhance trust in their online stores (Kwon and Lennon, 2009) and save the costs of establishing new store concepts or images on the Internet.

Perceived brand fit may be formed based on both functional and symbolic images of the entities. Thus, consumers' perceived e-store brand fit may be influenced both by how similar the e-store's concrete, functional characteristics (e.g. customer services, merchandise) are to the functional attributes and benefits consumers associate with the brand and by how congruent the abstract, symbolic characteristics of the e-store (e.g. the e-store personality conveyed by various design and atmospheric cues of the e-store) are with the symbolic image of the brand (e.g. the brand personality) (Park *et al.*, 1991). Therefore, perceived e-store brand fit can be regarded as the overall e-store brand image congruence encompassing both functional and symbolic image congruencies.

Arslan and Altuna (2010) stressed that consumers tended to evaluate the brand positively through the perception of fit based on the product-level similarity as well as based on the unique image associations with various attributes and benefits offered by the brand (Dwivedi *et al.*, 2010; Park *et al.*, 1991). Similarly, Eren-Erdogmus *et al.* (2018) identified factors influencing perceived fit, such as consumer personality, brand attitude and consumer values, including functional, hedonic and symbolic values. Among them, symbolic value is one of the necessary antecedents to form the perception of fit and the most significant driver of successful branding (Eren-Erdogmus *et al.*, 2018). Given this literature, it is feasible that the congruence between a retailer's brand personality and e-store personality, which constitutes large parts of the retailer's symbolic values, positively influences consumers' perceived overall fit of the e-store to the brand. d'Astous and Levesque (2003) also support this view by stressing that the overall brand image consists of functional and symbolic brand image aspects, and personality, as a symbolic image, does not substitute but complements the overall image. Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

- H1. The greater the e-store brand personality incongruence, the lower the perceived e-store brand fit.

E-store patronage intention

E-store patronage intention represents consumers' willingness to engage in diverse favorable behaviors toward an e-store, encompassing shopping at the e-store, spending time in it and recommending it to other consumers (Fiore *et al.*, 2005; Michon *et al.*, 2015; Wang *et al.*, 2007). Therefore, how perceived e-store brand perceived fit influences consumers' patronage intention toward the brand's e-store bears an important strategic meaning. Perceived fit has been found to be a significant predictor of consumer responses to a product extension. For instance, a poor perceived fit between an extension and its parent brand can hurt consumers' favorable associations or attitudes toward the parent brand and transfer undesirable or harmful messages to the extension (Chowdhury, 2007; Riley *et al.*, 2015). A low perceived fit between a parent brand and an extension can lead consumers to question the purpose of the

extension (Aaker and Keller, 1992; Riley *et al.*, 2015); whereas a high perceived fit generates consumers' favorable behavioral responses toward the extension, including increased purchase intention (Riley *et al.*, 2015). Given the analogy between brand extensions and retailers' multichannel expansions, the aforementioned findings on the brand-extension fit lend support for a prediction that perceived e-store brand fit has a positive influence on consumers' intention to patronize the e-store, as in the following hypothesis:

- H2. The greater the perceived e-store brand fit, the greater the e-store patronage intention.

As previously discussed, perceived e-store brand fit captures consumers' *global* perception of the fit between the brand and its e-store and thus encompasses all possible aspects consumers use to compare the brand and its e-store. On the other hand, e-store brand personality congruence/incongruence reflects the similarity/difference between the brand and the e-store *specific* to the personality dimension of symbolic images. Hence, we predict that the holistic perceived e-store brand fit is likely to be a more direct predictor of consumers' e-store patronage intention than the e-store brand personality incongruence operationalized as the difference between the brand and its e-store that is computed only in terms of personality. In other words, a multichannel retailer's e-store brand personality incongruence is likely to impact consumers' patronage intention toward the e-store indirectly through influencing the consumers' perceived e-store brand fit. The following hypothesis reflects this prediction:

- H3. Consumers' perceived e-store brand fit mediates the influence of the e-store brand personality incongruence on e-store patronage intention.

Self-relevance of the retail brand

The self-relevance of the retail brand refers to the extent to which consumers perceive a retail brand to be personally relevant to themselves and meet their needs/wants (Kwon and Lennon, 2009). Personal relevance has been known as a key motivator for thoughtful information processing. The elaboration likelihood model (Cacioppo and Petty, 1984) postulates that people process a communication with varying levels of *elaboration*, or extent of cognitive efforts exerted to think about issues in the message. People sometimes carefully process issues in a given communication (i.e. central-route processing), while other times they may pay little attention to them (i.e. peripheral-route processing) (Cacioppo and Petty, 1984). A plethora of the literature has proposed and empirically demonstrated personal relevance as a positive motivator of elaboration (e.g. Malodia *et al.*, 2017; Wheeler *et al.*, 2005). That is, when the message is perceived to be relevant to them, people tend to evaluate them with more critical eyes. As a result, elaboration levels impact persuasive outcomes in that individuals' response to a communication tends to be better in line with issue-relevant judgment in the high-elaboration, central-route processing mode than in the low-elaboration, peripheral-route processing mode (Cacioppo and Petty, 1984). For example, in the context of celebrity-endorsement based brand advertising, Malodia *et al.* (2017) found that the more involved the consumer was with the brand, the greater the impact of how well the celebrity reinforced the brand personality on the consumer's brand attitude. Based on this theoretical and empirical literature, it is plausible that when shopping in a multichannel apparel retail brand's e-store, consumers who feel the brand is highly relevant to them would be more likely to scrutinize the e-store brand fit and thus be more profoundly affected by this fit judgment in forming their e-store patronage intention as compared to consumers who find the brand irrelevant to them. No matter how well the e-store fits the retailer's brand image, if consumers think that the retailer does not offer the types of products they want or welcome the type of consumers they are, and thus is not relevant to them, the e-store brand fit will not matter to them. Hence, we predict the moderating role of the consumer's perceived self-relevance of the retail brand for

the relationship between perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention as follows:

- H4. The relationship between perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention is greater among consumers who perceive a high (vs low) level of self-relevance of the retail brand.

Methods

Sample and procedure

An online survey was conducted with a US national sample of 458 female online clothing shoppers (20–50 years old), recruited from a market research firm's consumer panel. Only a female sample was recruited for the gender consistency between the sample and the target market of the brands used in this study because two (*Coldwater Creek* and *Talbots*) of the six brands used in this study were considered targeting only female consumers. Moreover, researchers have shown that fashion brands' symbolic image is of a higher value to women than to men (Stokburger-Sauer and Teichmann, 2013), which further justifies the use of a female sample.

On the questionnaire, respondents were first asked to complete the brand personality and brand self-relevance measures for an apparel retail brand randomly assigned to them among six brands selected for this study (*Abercrombie and Fitch*, *Gap*, *Coldwater Creek*, *Talbots*, *Michael Kors* and *Burberry*). We used multiple brands, instead of a single brand, as the contexts in which respondents completed the survey to enhance the generalizability through stimulus sampling. Random assignments of participants to the brands were expected to help avoid bias in the sample-brand groupings while generating a sufficient variance in the relevance of the brand to the participant. The six brands were selected through a content analysis of over 30 apparel brands and their e-stores. In the open-coding process, two coders coded the apparel brands in terms of (1) the visual merchandising cues (e.g. the types of editorial/ad visuals, background vs font colors, the imagery of human models) used by the e-stores to convey symbolic e-store images and (2) the functional features of the e-store (e.g. merchandise carried, merchandise categorization methods). Then, the researchers conducted an axial coding process by integrating the open codes to identify potential types of symbolic images conveyed by the e-stores (e.g. young vs mature user imagery, exciting vs calm brand personality, high vs moderate social status of target consumers), which informed our selection of the six brands. Care was taken to select brands that represented diverse types of symbolic e-store images.

After completing the brand personality and self-relevance measures, respondents were given a link to their assigned apparel brand's e-store. Respondents were asked to browse the e-store (which was open on a new window upon clicking on the given link) to select a pair of pants that they would like to buy for themselves, return to the survey website and enter the item number or name of the pants that they selected. This process ensured that respondents had a chance to browse their assigned e-store and form an impression of the e-store's image including its personality. Following the e-store browsing task, respondents filled out the remaining questionnaire including measures for e-store personality, perceived e-store brand fit, e-store patronage intention and demographic items (age, education level, ethnicity and annual household income).

The mean age of the respondents was 37.4 years old ($SD = 8.17$). The sample size was similar across the six brands (74–80 per brand). Most respondents had at least some college education (87.6%), were non-Hispanic White (74.0%) and came from a household with incomes that ranged between \$35,001 and \$100,000 (61.8%).

Instruments

Self-relevance of the retail brand was measured with five self-relevance sub-scale items adapted from Kwon and Lennon's (2009) offline brand belief scale. Perceived e-store brand fit

was measured by three Likert-scale items inspired by Becker-Olsen and Hill's (2006) perceived fit scale. Becker-Olsen and Hill (2006) used a semantic differential scale including seven pairs of bipolar adjectives or phrases to measure perceived fit between a brand and its sponsorship program. In this study, three of their items (dissimilar/similar, inconsistent/consistent and unrepresentative/representative) were selected and modified in declarative statements (see Table 1) that clearly communicate the e-store brand fit context used in this study while preserving the fit concepts (i.e. similarity, consistency and representativeness) captured in the original items. To measure e-store patronage intention, we used seven items in a Likert scale format including four new items and three items modified from previous studies (Fiore *et al.*, 2005; Wang *et al.*, 2007). The self-relevance, perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention items were all rated using a 5-point scale (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree; see Table 1 for item wordings).

Each of brand personality and e-store personality was measured using a scale adapted from d'Astous and Levesque's (2003) store personality scale. The validity and reliability of this scale have been established in past research in both offline (d'Astous and Levesque, 2003; Michon *et al.*, 2015) and online store contexts (Poddar *et al.*, 2009). The original scale consists of 20 pairs of bipolar adjectives describing five store personality dimensions including enthusiasm, sophistication, genuineness, solidity and unpleasantness. In this study, the personality adjectives were modified into a sentence format (e.g. "this brand [or this website] is dynamic") to fit the brand and e-store personality contexts and were rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree) (see Table 2).

Results

Preliminary analyses

Since this study adapted d'Astous and Levesque's (2003) store personality scale with significant modifications to measure personality in the two contexts (brand personality and e-store personality), we first conducted exploratory factor analysis (EFA) for each of the contexts, using principal components analysis with varimax rotation and then compared the brand and e-store EFA results to identify a common factor structure applicable to both contexts. As a result of the initial EFA, five items, which cross-loaded on multiple factors or loaded on different factors for the brand and e-store contexts were eliminated. The final EFA

Variable	Items
Self-relevance of the retail brand	(1) I enjoy shopping in this brand's stores
	(2) I like the way this brand's clothes look on me
	(3) This brand appeals to people like me
	(4) I like this brand's clothes
	(5) I shop at this brand's stores often
Perceived e-store brand fit	(1) The impression of this website is similar to the brand's image
	(2) The impression of this website is consistent with the brand's image
	(3) This website represents the brand's image very well
E-store patronage intention	(1) The likelihood that I would make a purchase at this website in the future is very high
	(2) I would be willing to purchase from this website
	(3) I would recommend this website to my friend
	(4) I would spend more time than planned at this website
	(5) I would visit this website again
	(6) I intend to shop at this website in the future
	(7) In the future, this website would be one of the first places I would look when I need to find clothing items

Table 1.
Measurements:
self-relevance,
perceived e-store brand
fit and e-store
patronage intention

Component and item ^{a,b}		Brand personality			E-store personality				E-store brand personality congruence
	Loading	AVE	CR	Cronbach's α	Loading	AVE	CR	Cronbach's α	
<i>Enthusiasm</i>		0.65	0.85	0.84		0.74	0.90	0.89	167
Enthusiastic	0.83				0.80				
Dynamic	0.77				0.77				
Lively	0.77				0.74				
<i>Sophistication</i>		0.70	0.82	0.82		0.73	0.85	0.85	
High class	0.84				0.86				
Elegant	0.83				0.81				
<i>Genuineness</i>		0.68	0.94	0.94		0.67	0.93	0.93	
Sincere	0.82				0.75				
Solid	0.78				0.68				
Honest	0.78				0.79				
Reliable	0.77				0.74				
Hardy	0.75				0.63				
Trustful	0.70				0.80				
Welcoming	0.69				0.62				
<i>Unpleasantness</i>		0.65	0.84	0.84		0.73	0.90	0.89	
Irritating	0.83				0.88				
Superficial	0.77				0.80				
Annoying	0.86				0.89				

Note(s): ^aAll item wordings began with “this brand is” and “this website is” for the brand personality and e-store personality, respectively, followed by the adjectives listed here; ^bThe five items eliminated from the final measurement as a result of the EFA include “[This brand is, This website is]reputable,” “stylish,” “chic,” “loud,” and “thriving”

Table 2.
CFA results: brand personality and e-store personality

with the remaining 15 items revealed a consistent four-factor structure for both contexts. The four factors were labeled as enthusiasm, sophistication, genuineness and unpleasantness, following the original dimension names from d'Astous and Levesque (2003). Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was then run with the finalized 15-item, 4-factor model, which revealed a good fit for both brand personality ($\chi^2 = 259.8$, $df = 84$, $p < 0.001$; NFI = 0.95, TLI = 0.95, CFI = 0.96; RMSEA = 0.068) and e-store personality ($\chi^2 = 312.1$, $df = 84$, $p < 0.001$; NFI = 0.94, TLI = 0.94, CFI = 0.96; RMSEA = 0.077). The average variance extracted (AVE) and composite reliability (CR) estimates were greater than 0.65 for all four personality factors for both brands and e-stores (see Table 2), which indicated the convergent validity of the factors (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). The AVE estimates were greater than all of the squared factor correlations for both the brand (0.11–0.45) and e-store (0.12–0.63) contexts, which suggests the discriminant validity among the personality factors. All four factors showed acceptable reliability (Cronbach α s > 0.80) for both the brand and e-store data (see Table 2).

The six brands' brand personality and e-store personality factor mean scores revealed variabilities within and across the brands (see Table 3). For example, Talbots was perceived to be the most enthusiastic ($M = 3.6$) but the least sophisticated ($M = 2.7$) brand among the six brands, whereas Burberry was perceived to be the least enthusiastic ($M = 3.1$) but the most sophisticated ($M = 3.6$) brand. The brand and e-store personality scores tended to trend together but were not exactly identical, suggesting the ecological validity of the e-store brand personality incongruence construct. For example, although Burberry was the most sophisticated brand, its e-store was perceived to be less sophisticated than Michael Kors' ($M_{\text{Burberry}} = 3.8$, $M_{\text{Michael Kors}} = 4.0$).

To operationalize e-store brand personality incongruence based on the e-store personality and brand personality scores, the absolute difference between the respondent's average brand personality factor score and e-store personality factor score was computed in each of

Brand	Brand personality ^a			E-store personality ^a			E-store brand personality incongruence ^a			Perceived e-store brand fit	E-store patronage intention			
	E	S	G	E	S	G	E	S	G			U		
Abercrombie & Fitch	3.10	3.30	3.42	2.46	3.25	3.59	3.76	2.07	0.50	0.53	0.41	0.66	3.92	3.04
Gap	3.17	3.15	3.43	2.49	3.40	3.38	3.65	2.09	0.49	0.52	0.34	0.55	3.86	3.15
Coldwater creek	3.45	2.94	3.12	3.13	3.25	2.88	3.12	3.17	0.51	0.63	0.39	0.77	3.75	2.46
Talbots	3.59	2.70	3.59	2.38	3.60	2.98	3.67	2.33	0.45	0.43	0.31	0.50	3.95	3.17
Michael Kors	3.49	3.60	3.37	2.52	3.36	4.00	3.44	2.42	0.53	0.63	0.38	0.60	3.64	2.70
Burberry	3.08	3.63	3.33	2.75	3.16	3.81	3.33	2.73	0.67	0.61	0.46	0.70	3.74	2.45
Total	3.32	3.22	3.37	2.63	3.33	3.44	3.47	2.48	0.52	0.56	0.38	0.63	3.81	2.82

Note(s): ^aE = Enthusiasm, S = Sophistication, G = Genuineness, U = Unpleasantness

the four personality dimensions, following the indirect approach to measure image incongruence frequently used in the literature (e.g. Esmaeilpour, 2015; Hu *et al.*, 2012; Sirgy *et al.*, 1997; Vigolo and Ugolini, 2016). For example, each respondent's incongruence in the enthusiasm dimension was calculated by taking the absolute difference between (1) the average of the three enthusiasm items' scores for the e-store and (2) the average of the three enthusiasm items' scores for the brand. The bigger the absolute difference, the higher the incongruence and thus the lower the congruence. The e-store brand personality incongruence scores ranged 0–2.0 in genuineness, 0–2.5 in sophistication, 0–3.0 in enthusiasm and 0–4.0 in unpleasantness (see Table 3 for means by brand and total).

Hypothesis testing

Structural equation modeling (SEM) was run using AMOS 25 to test the hypotheses. Before running the SEM, a CFA was first conducted to examine the measurement model of the three latent variables: e-store brand personality incongruence, perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention. The initial CFA resulted in an acceptable model fit (TLI, NFI and CFI > 0.95; RMSEA < 0.08), but produced a low factor loading (= 0.54) of the “unpleasantness incongruence” indicator for the e-store brand personality incongruence factor. Given that this indicator reflects the only negatively-worded personality dimension, its lack of convergent validity was not surprising. Thus, another CFA was run after eliminating the unpleasant incongruence indicator, which resulted in a good fit ($\chi^2 = 240.2$, $df = 62$, $p < 0.001$; NFI = 0.95, TLI = 0.95, CFI = 0.96; RMSEA = 0.079).

To assess the convergent validity of the measurement model, the values of factor loadings, AVE and CR have been reviewed (Hair *et al.*, 2015; Jain, 2019). The AVE of one factor, e-store brand personality incongruence, was below the recommended threshold of 0.50 (see Table 4). However, literature guides that a scale can be considered as adequate if other measures support convergent validity because AVE is more conservative compared to other measures (Aliyev and Wagner, 2018; Fornell and Larcker, 1981; Malhotra and Dash, 2011), and thus CR and factor loadings were further examined. CR values were greater than 0.70 (ranging from 0.71 to 0.96) for all factors including e-store brand personality incongruence, indicating their convergent validity (Fornell and Larcker, 1981; Lee and Lee, 2018) (see Table 4). All factor loadings were statistically significant, and their estimated values were within the acceptable range (>0.60) for all indicators except for the sophistication incongruence indicator ($\lambda = 0.59$), which was still above the threshold factor loading of 0.50 (Hair *et al.*, 2015). Literature suggests that indicators with factor loadings between 0.40 and 0.70 can remain in the model if they contribute to content validity (Aliyev and Wagner, 2018; Hair *et al.*, 2011).

All AVEs were larger than all of the squared factor correlations (see Table 4), which established the discriminant validity among the factors (Fornell and Larcker, 1981; Lee and Lee, 2018). Finally, the internal consistency of all of the factors was established through the high CR values (Hair *et al.*, 2015) and Cronbach's α s greater than 0.70 (Nunnally and Bernstein, 1994) (see Table 4).

Latent variable	AVE and squared factor correlation ^a			CR	Cronbach's α
	A	B	C		
E-store brand incongruence (A)	<i>0.45</i>			0.71	0.71
E-store/brand fit (B)	0.02	<i>0.67</i>		0.91	0.85
E-store patronage (C)	0.03	0.27	<i>0.79</i>	0.96	0.97

Note(s): ^aThe italic numbers in diagonal cells are AVEs, while those in the off-diagonal cells are squared factor correlations

Table 4.
Measurement model
CFA results: AVEs,
squared factor
correlations and
Cronbach's α s of the
latent variables

The SEM model for testing hypotheses 1 through 3 was specified as presented in Figure 1 and run with maximum likelihood estimation method and 5,000 bootstrapping samples. The fit of this SEM model was acceptable ($\chi^2 = 240.2$, $df = 62$, $p < 0.001$; TLI = 0.95, NFI = 0.95, CFI = 0.96; RMSEA = 0.079). Both H1 and H2 were supported through the respective regression coefficients, which indicated that e-store brand personality incongruence negatively influenced perceived e-store brand fit ($\beta = -0.15$, $p < 0.05$), which in turn positively influenced e-store patronage intention ($\beta = 0.51$, $p < 0.001$). This result indicates that e-store brand incongruence has a negative impact on e-store brand fit, while perceived e-store fit positively influences e-store patronage intention.

The direct path from e-store brand personality incongruence to e-store patronage intention was non-significant ($\beta = -0.09$, $p = 0.09$) in this model; although an additional SEM model which separately examined it without the perceived e-store brand fit mediator showed a significant relationship between the incongruence and intention variables ($\beta = -0.16$, $p < 0.01$). The indirect effect of e-store brand incongruence on e-store patronage intention via perceived e-store brand fit was significant (effect size = -0.074 [-0.15 , -0.01], $p < 0.05$). Combined, these results support H3 by showing evidence for the full mediation of perceived e-store brand fit for the relationship between e-store brand personality incongruence and e-store patronage intention.

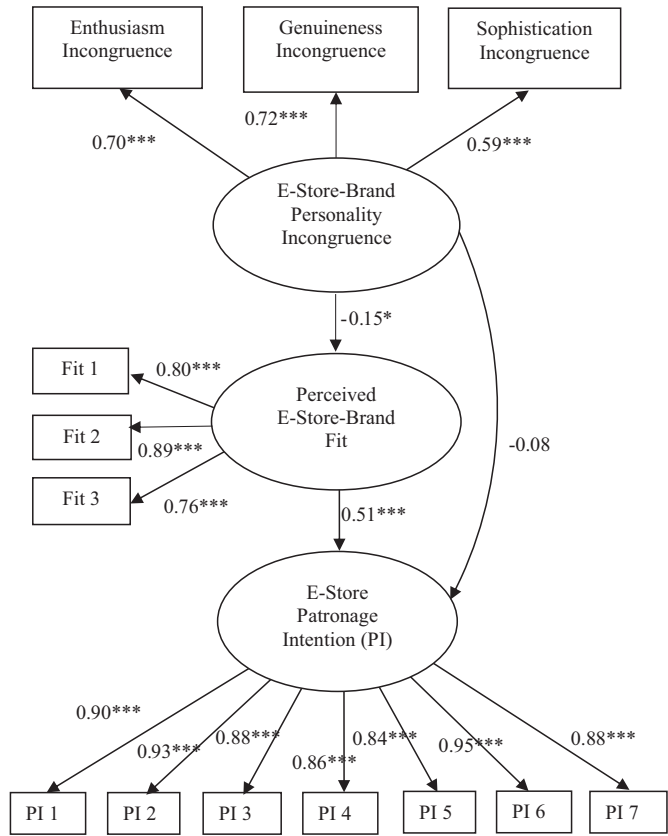


Figure 1.
SEM model and
results. All error terms
are omitted, and no
error terms are
correlated

Note(s): * $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.001$

To test H4 (the moderating role of perceived self-relevance of the brand), multiple-group SEM was conducted with the high and low self-relevance groups created by a median split of perceived self-relevance factor scores ($M_{\text{high}} = 3.7, M_{\text{low}} = 2.1, p < 0.001$). Prior to the SEM, an EFA and Cronbach's α (0.92) verified the unidimensionality and internal consistency of the self-relevance measure, respectively. The multiple-group SEM results revealed that the relationship between perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention was stronger among the high self-relevance group ($\beta = 64, p < 0.001$) than among the low self-relevance group ($\beta = 0.25, p < 0.01$). This result indicates that self-relevance significantly moderates the relationship between e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention in that this relationship is more salient for consumers with high self-relevance than consumers with low self-relevance. This group difference was statistically supported through a chi-square difference test between this model and another model with this regression coefficient restricted to be equal between the high and low self-relevance groups ($\Delta\chi^2 = 17.51, \Delta df = 1, p < 0.001$). Thus, H4 was supported. Further, an additional moderation test was run using multiple regression analysis employing (1) the composite score of the three perceived e-store brand fit items, (2) the composite score of the five self-relevance items and (3) the interaction term created by multiplying these two composite scores as three predictors of e-store patronage intention. Results from this analysis again confirmed the significant moderating effect of self-relevance by showing a significant positive effect of the self-relevance $\times$ fit interaction term ($\beta = 0.84, p < 0.001$), providing additional support for H4.

Discussion

In this study, the symbolic image congruence between the multichannel retail brand and its e-store was operationalized in terms of the personality discrepancy in three dimensions: enthusiasm, sophistication and genuineness. This personality-based symbolic image incongruence significantly predicts the consumer's perceived e-store brand fit, or global judgment of the congruence of the e-store image to the retail brand image. This result suggests personality, specifically the three personality factors, as a potential strategic dimension to control consumers' overall e-store brand fit perception. The findings of this study further indicate that consumers' perceived e-store brand fit significantly influences their patronage intention toward the multichannel retailer's e-store and that this fit perception is a more direct and stronger influencer of the consumer's e-store patronage intention than the e-store brand personality (in)congruence. This finding advocates the importance of brand fit of an e-store in fostering consumers' positive relationship with the e-store and suggests a critical need to delve into various additional potential factors impacting perceived e-store brand fit besides e-store brand personality incongruence examined in this study. Lastly, the findings of this study show that the influence of e-store brand fit is far greater among consumers who perceive a high (vs low) self-relevance of the retail brand. That is, an apparel brand's e-store's fit with the brand's image matters more to consumers who have liked and frequently used the brand and thus have felt the brand is highly relevant to them, as compared to consumers who are new to the brand or who have not liked the brand and thus feel less self-relevance to the brand. Retailers' 80–20 rule (i.e. 80% of sales come from 20% of a retailer's customers) stresses the importance of satisfying a small number of loyal customers who bring the most profit to the retailer (Levy *et al.*, 2014), who are expected to feel the most self-relevance of the retailer. The findings of this study clearly indicate the strategic importance of maintaining an e-store well-fitting the brand image from the customer relationship management perspective.

Theoretical implications

This study makes several significant contributions to the literature. First, this study expands brand image congruence research to the cross-channel congruence phenomenon in the

multichannel retailing context. Although research on cross-channel congruence exists, surprisingly little attention has been paid to the issue of cross-channel symbolic image congruence, such as designing e-store interfaces to generate e-store personality impressions reflecting brand personality, as compared to the cross-channel functional integration effect. Further, previous studies identifying strong linkages between brand image congruence and consumer behaviors have been conducted mainly in a single business channel, such as the contexts of brand extension (e.g. Chowdhury, 2007; Yuan *et al.*, 2016), product branding (Yuan *et al.*, 2016) and service marketing (Bairrada *et al.*, 2019; Islam *et al.*, 2019; Vinyals-Mirabent and Mohammadi, 2018). This study addresses this literature gap by providing empirical evidence to suggest the critical significance of personality-based cross-channel symbolic image integration of multichannel apparel retailers.

Second, this study examined multichannel retailers' cross-channel image congruence issues both at the global image congruence level (i.e. perceived e-store brand fit) and at a specific symbolic personality level (i.e. e-store brand personality congruence). Although perceived e-store brand fit is a more direct and holistic construct of congruence between a multichannel retailer's brand image and its e-store image perceived by consumers, examining it alone would not provide specific actionable insights on the source of this fit perception. Our findings uncover the intimate connection of personality congruence to an overall e-store brand fit perception, suggesting personality as a critical factor in the cross-channel image congruence management. This study also extends the brand personality and store personality literature, which advocates the significant role of personality congruence in attracting positive consumer response (e.g. Bajac *et al.*, 2018; Erdogmus and Budeyri-Turan, 2012; Pradhan *et al.*, 2016), by offering empirical evidence specifically for three positive personality dimensions (i.e. genuine, sophisticated and enthusiastic) that play a role in consumers' perception of e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention.

Finally, this study contributes to the cognitive psychology literature as well as the image congruence literature by offering empirical evidence for the role of personal relevance in the consumer's image information processing and persuasion. The significant interaction between self-relevance and e-store brand fit found in this study demonstrates that consumers' judgment of the e-store brand fit has a greater impact when consumers feel higher self-relevance to the brand, which motivates them to process more critically the congruence of the e-store to the retail brand image to form their behavioral intention toward the e-store. This finding extends the applicability of the elaboration likelihood model (Cacioppo and Petty, 1984), which predicts the role of relevance in facilitating elaborate information processing, to the context of consumers' processing of image information (i.e. brand image and e-store image). Existing research in image congruence has mainly focused on the direct effect of congruence between the consumer's self-image and the image of the brand or the store (or e-store), such as brand-self congruence (e.g. Bairrada *et al.*, 2019; Islam *et al.*, 2019), store-self congruence (Sung and Huddleston, 2018) and the e-store-self congruence (e.g. Chang and Kwon, 2017), on consumer responses to the brand or the (e-)store. This study takes a unique look at the relationship among the triad of the consumer, the brand and its e-store by integrating the cognitive psychology perspective into the image congruence perspective and provides a new insight on how the consumer's self-relevance to the brand interacts with the under-investigated image congruence between the brand and its e-store (i.e. perceived e-store brand fit) to drive the consumer's patronage toward the brand's e-store.

Managerial implications

The current study contributes practical guidelines with regard to multichannel retail brands' e-store design. First, this study reveals that enhancing cross-channel image similarity, consistency, or connectedness is a key factor for successful multichannel apparel retailing, and particularly the symbolic image congruence in *personality* may be key to multichannel

apparel retailers' cross-channel brand management. Therefore, multichannel apparel retail brand managers should carefully identify their brand personality and integrate it into their e-store interface design (e.g. the esthetic execution of the e-store design that matches its brand personality) and e-store visual merchandising (e.g. the selection of merchandise that is displayed on the e-store and the methods in which merchandise is displayed) to convey an e-store personality that is consistent with the retail brand's personality.

Second, this study shows that a mismatch between a consumer's existing perceptions of the retailer's brand personality negatively impacts perceived image fit between the brand and its e-store and eventually may harm patronage intention for the retailer's e-store, especially among the retailer's target consumer group, who may feel the mismatch more acutely than consumers who do not see the retailer has much to offer them. New customers, who are not well aware of the brand's image and thus have not formed a sense of self-relevance to the brand, may not be bothered by an image misfit of the e-store to the brand. However, the misfit between the brand image and the e-store image may have a detrimental impact on loyal customers who feel high relevance of the brand to themselves, which may lead to harming the customers' relationships with the brand and discouraging them from using the brand's e-store. Given that apparel brands always strive to enhance their relevance to their target customers and maintain their relevance to their loyal customers, the findings of this study lend a critical implication for the importance of designing and executing a brand's e-store with their target and/or loyal customers' perceived image of the brand in mind. Brands need to manage target consumers by offering consistent and meaningful brand associations to induce a high image fit. Further, brands need to increase their level of relevance to the target customer by examining their needs and wants continuously to satisfy their expectations and achieve a stronger brand loyalty (Savastano *et al.*, 2019).

In conclusion, a lack of image congruence caused by personality mismatches between the retail channels can potentially result in a detrimental feedback effect on the retail brand image by diluting the true identity of the retailer in the consumer's minds (Islam *et al.*, 2019). Therefore, the seamless cross-channel integration using intangible symbolic image congruence, such as personality congruence, must be carefully executed for multichannel retail branding (Riley *et al.*, 2015). Retailers should view multichannel retailing strategies from an integrated brand management perspective so that their customers can have a unified shopping experience, consistent and effective, across multiple channels both symbolically and functionally (Cho and Workman, 2011; Savastano *et al.*, 2019). The symbolic integration through shared personality and other self-expressive benefits as well as the functional integration focusing on consistency in tangible attributes (e.g. merchandise accessibility, product availability, product feature/category similarity, technology, customer service, product quality, price) between channels should be assured for successful multichannel branding (Arslan and Altuna, 2010; Eren-Erdogmus *et al.*, 2018; Hu *et al.*, 2012; Savastano *et al.*, 2019).

Limitations and recommendations

Findings from this study should be understood with caution in light of the following limitations. First, this study focuses on the cross-channel image congruence from the symbolic image perspective. In doing so, the potential congruence dimensions from the functional image perspective were not included in this study. Further, among many potential symbolic image dimensions, this study focuses only on the personality-based image by examining the e-store brand personality (in)congruence in the three personality dimensions (enthusiasm, genuineness and sophistication). In addition, the e-store brand personality incongruence factor had a low AVE, which may raise a convergent validity concern although CR and factor loadings were acceptable. Therefore, future research is recommended to pursue

more comprehensive insights on the cross-channel image congruence effects in various symbolic and functional image dimensions and use more valid assessment methods for symbolic image congruence.

Second, although self-relevance has been incorporated in this study as a moderator, a perception of self-relevance of a retail brand may stem from many specific factors of the retailer or the consumer (e.g. social status, merchandise style, personality); therefore, future research addressing how different factors of self-relevance may moderate the relationship between e-store brand fit and e-store patronage is recommended to generate clearer insights to help businesses to connect with consumers. Further, results of this study might have been impacted by additional potential confounding variables, such as consumers' level of different brand associations, including prior brand knowledge, experience, or familiarity with the brand/e-store and their personality or shopping tendencies, which were unaccounted for in this study. Future research with the inclusion of these potential confounding variables as moderators may provide valuable insights on how consumers' sensitivity to the cross-channel image (in)congruence effect may vary depending on levels of the moderators.

Last, because the sample consisted of only female consumers from certain age groups, the findings may not be generalized to other populations. Further, although care was taken to use brands representing a variety of personality characteristics in this study, the generalizability beyond the six apparel retailers used in this study may be limited. Future research is recommended to extend this study to other populations (e.g. men, a generation Y cohort, or consumers from different cultures) and to e-store contexts of other brands or other product categories, so that the external validity of the findings can be enhanced. Further, this study included only the e-store channel to examine the brand image congruence effect. Additional research delving into image congruence across more diverse retail channels, such as mobile commerce, voice-commerce and social media, may offer more comprehensive insights into the cross-channel image congruence issue for strategic omnichannel branding.

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